opium. On the night of 24 January 1556 he went up to the roof of his library with his astrologer to watch Venus rising. On hearing the muezzin's call to prayer, Humayun hurried down the steep, shadowy steps of the library, tripped on his long fur robes, and fell down the stone stairs. Three days later, just six months after regaining his throne, the Padshah of Hindustan was dead.

When news reached Akbar at Kalanaur, almost 500 kilometres away from Delhi, that his father had died, he was inconsolable. He wept, we are told, and 'was upset beyond human imagination'. Maham Anaga and Shamsuddin Ataka Khan tried to console the young prince but their attempts only increased his sobs. Akbar was only thirteen years old when Humayun died and very unlike his father physically. He was of average height but broad in the shoulders and, at this age, had not even a wisp of a whisker. In Kabul, Humayun's other surviving son, Mirza Hakim, was just two years old. But despite Akbar's youth and sorrow, Bairam Khan could not afford to wait while the prince grieved. The death of Humayun had been hidden from the populace and the soldiery, given the precariousness of the nascent empire. In Kalanaur, therefore, on the banks of the Ravi, on a hastily constructed brick throne set in a garden, Akbar was proclaimed Padshah, third of the Mughals of Hindustan.

Akbar's grandiose title notwithstanding, Mughal claims to sovereignty in Hindustan were gossamer thin. The remarkable reign of the Pashtun Afghan Sur clan had come to an end but there were still individual Sur pretenders who sought to challenge the audacious claims of this young Mughal parvenu. Sikandar Shah Sur was still a dangerous presence in the Punjab while Adil Shah remained truculent in Bihar. Even the territories controlled by the Mughals were more in the form of garrison towns rather than substantial holdings. Moreover, the Surs had ruled peacefully for fifteen years, which was as long as the rule of Babur and Humayun combined. As historian Annemarie Schimmel has noted, 'Akbar's territories were hemmed in by rivals. To the north, Kashmir, Sind…were fully independent'. Kabul was nominally under Mirza Hakim, Bengal was an independent kingdom as were Malwa, Gujarat, and Orissa. This was also true of many of the Rajput clans. The Deccan sultanates held sway in the south while further away still Vijayanagar was a Hindu kingdom. The Portuguese held ports, including Goa. The Mughal Empire, paltry as it was at this time, consisted of 'seven or eight military zones, commanded by